together cover less than 2 percent of the earth land area, the number of species they harbour is extremely high and protection of these hotspots could reduce the ongoing mass.

Protected Areas

These are biogeographical areas where biological diversity along with natural and cultural resources is protected, maintained and managed through legal measures. protected areas include national parks, wild life sanctuaries, community reserves and biosphere reserves. World Conservation monitoring centre has recognized 37,000 protected areas world-wide. India has about 771 protected areas covering 162099 km^2 comprising of National Parks (104), Wild Life Sanctuaries (544), biosphere reserves (18) and several sacred groves.

National Parks (NP)

It is a natural habitat that is notified by the state government to be constituted as a National Park due to its ecological, faunal, floral, geomorphological, or zoological association of importance. No human activity is permitted inside the national park except the activities permitted by the Chief Wildlife Warden of the state under the conditions given in CHAPTER IV, of the Wildlife Protection Act (WPA) 1972 **(Table 12.2).**

Table 12.2 National Parks in Tamil Nadu

National Parks in Tamil Nadu	Year of establishment	District(s)
Guindy NP	1977	Chennai
Gulf of Mannar Marine NP	1986	Ramanathpuram and Tuticorin
Indira Gandhi (Annamalai) NP	1976	Coimbatore
Mudumalai NP	1940	Nilgiris
Mukurthi NP	2001	Nilgiris

There are 104 existing national parks in India covering an area of 40,501 km^2, which is 1.23% of the geographical area of the country (National Wildlife Database, Aug. 2018). National Park is an area which is strictly reserved for the betterment of wildlife and biodiversity and where activities like development, forestry, poaching, hunting, grazing and cultivation are not permitted. They are large areas of scenic and national beauty maintained for scientific educational and recreational use. They are not used for commercial extraction of resources. Kaziranga National park is a protected area for the one Horned Rhinoceros in Assam.

Wild Life Sanctuaries (WLS)

Any area other than the area comprised with any reserve forest or the territorial waters can be notified by the State Government to constitute as a sanctuary if such area is of adequate ecological, faunal, floral, geomorphological, natural or zoological significance. This is for the purpose of protecting, endangered factual species. Some restricted human activities are allowed inside the Sanctuary area details of which are given in CHAPTER IV, of the Wildlife Protection Act (WPA) 1972. Ecoturism is permitted, as long as animal life is undistrubed.

There are 544 existing wildlife sanctuaries in India covering an area of 118,918 km^2, which is 3.62 % of the geographical area of the country (National Wildlife Database, 2017).

Sanctuaries are tracts of land where wild animals and fauna can take refuge without being hunted or poached. Other activities like collection of forest products, regulated harvesting of timber, private ownership of land are permitted. Periyar wild life sanctuary in Kerala is famous for the Indian Tiger and Asiatic Elephant **(Table 12.3).**

Table 12.3 Wild life sanctuaries in Tamil Nadu

Prominent WLS in Tamil Nadu	Year of establishment	Districts
Vedanthangal Lake Birds WLS	1936	Chengalpet
Mudumalai WLS	1942	Nilgiris
Point Calimere WLS	1967	Nagapattinam
Indira Gandhi (Annamalai) WLS	1976	Coimbatore
Mundanthurai WLS	1988	Tirunelveli

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